rhetoric positively affected approval and fairness, though only the fairness outcome reached statistical significance. The interaction between Trump voters and the populist treatment was highly significant for both dependent variables, indicating that these respondents drove the observed effects.

Our findings demonstrate that IOs can enhance public support by adopting populist-style rhetoric, particularly among audiences sympathetic to populist leaders. By framing their mission as aligned with the interests of "ordinary people" and opposing elites, IOs can effectively counter populist narratives and improve their perceived legitimacy.

While the elite-style treatment underscores IOs' technocratic strengths, it appears less effective in resonating with public audiences. This suggests that IOs seeking broader public approval should consider employing messaging strategies that prioritize relatability and accessibility over expertise.

7.5 Testing an Additional Implication: Centralization

Our theory suggests that IOs respond to populist challenges by centralizing their public communication efforts. Public communication involves the "organizational structures that enable IOs to regularly engage with nongovernmental audiences, including media outlets, experts, lobby groups, movements, and the general public," while centralization entails the creation of dedicated administrative capacities to manage and deliver consistent messaging to these audiences (Ecker-Ehrhardt 2018b, 522). This centralization might involve hiring additional staff for public outreach, expanding social media operations, or coordinating a unified communication strategy.

TABLE 7.4. Experimental regression results

	Dependent variable			
	Approval		**Fairness**	
	(1)	**(2)**	**(3)**	**(4)**
Populism treatment	0.105	0.010	0.139**	0.058
	(0.066)	(0.076)	(0.060)	(0.071)
Trump voter		−0.860***		−0.480***

Note: *p <0.1; **p <0.05; ***p <0.01